Step by step: make peace with a food you hate

צעד אחר צעד: להשלים עם אוכל שאתם שונאים

Until I was 19, I ate rice, meat, chicken and potatoes, and that was it. No fresh vegetables apart from cucumber, no sauces, no mayo, no mustard. I was a nightmare for other families to host. Today I eat all of it, and it started with one tiny taste. **This is the ladder I used.**

Why it works

למה זה עובד

In Emotional Intelligence (1995), Daniel Goleman describes the amygdala as the brain's alarm and a storehouse of emotional memory. So a food can set off the alarm before you even think.

In my view, understanding that is not enough. You need a **corrective experience**: a new, safe, positive experience with the thing you fear, repeated until it slowly rewrites the old alarm.

Before you start

לפני שמתחילים

- Pick **one** food. Just one.
- Pick a **favourite food** to pair it with (bread, rice, anything you love).
- Pick a **calm time** (not hungry, not rushed) and, if you can, a **person you trust**.
- Rate how uncomfortable the food feels from 0 (fine) to 10 (no way).

The ladder

הסולם

1	**Have it near you.** Put it on the table during a meal. No eating, just sitting with it.	שיהיה לידכם
2	**Smell it.** One sniff, then carry on with your meal.	להריח
3	**Touch it.** Hold a piece, feel it, put it down.	לגעת
4	**A tiny taste.** The size of a grain of rice. You are allowed to spit it out.	טעימה קטנטנה
5	**A tiny piece with a favourite.** On bread, inside rice, with something you love.	חתיכה עם אוכל אהוב
6	**A real bite on its own.** Chew slowly, notice what is actually there.	ביס אמיתי, לבד
7	**A small portion, then a full portion.** You made it. Keep it on the menu.	מנה קטנה, ואז מלאה

Stay on a step for a few days, or until it feels like a 3 out of 10 or less. Then move up one. Slow is the point.

Tips for corrective experiences

טיפים לחוויה מתקנת

• **Small doses.** Smaller than you think. Ridiculous is fine.	• **Repeat.** The same step, again and again. Repetition is what rewrites the alarm.
• **Calm setting.** Not when you are stressed, hungry or in a hurry.	• **People you trust.** No teasing, no pressure, no audience.
• **Say something kind out loud.** "Tasty." "This is OK." It sounds silly, and it helps.	• **Change the form.** Seeds out, cut tiny, cooked instead of raw, a milder version.
• **Too much? Go back one step,** and try again tomorrow. Not failure, the method.	• **Celebrate each step.** You are teaching your brain that this food is safe.

My 2-week tracker

מעקב לשבועיים

My food: _____ My favourite to pair it with: _____

Day	Step (1 to 7)	What I did	Before (0 to 10)	After (0 to 10)	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					

Before and after: how uncomfortable it felt, 0 (fine) to 10 (no way). Gold line: end of week one.

A gentle note

הערה חשובה

This guide is for everyday picky eating, shared from my own experience. If eating problems are severe, affect your health, or cause you real distress, please talk to a professional.